

How Character.AI Communicated the Risks of Parasocial Chatbot Relationships During Public Scrutiny

Executive Summary

This incident report aims to analyze how Character.AI communicated about the emotional and psychological risks of parasocial chatbot relationships, and how effective the communication was at addressing public concerns. Between 2024 and 2025, Character.AI began to face increased public scrutiny following media investigations and lawsuits linking chatbot use to severe mental health outcomes, including the death of a minor (Bhuiyan, 2025; Morrone, 2025). While Character.AI introduced policy changes, including placing restrictions on how minors can use the platform, the general public remained skeptical and trust continued to erode.

This report analyzes Character.AI's communication through qualitative analysis of many primary sources, including the Character.AI Safety Center, Community Guidelines, and the Terms of Service (Character.AI, 2025 December; Character.AI, n.d.; Character.AI, 2025 August). This report also examines secondary sources such as media coverage and expert commentary (Bhuiyan, 2025; Morrone, 2025; UNESCO, 2025). The analysis focuses on how language, organization, visibility, and responsibility framing shaped user expectations and public perceptions of safety.

The findings show that Character.AI constantly minimized their responsibility in the psychological crisis surrounding their platform. Character.AI used conditional language, shifted responsibility onto users, and displayed safety messaging in areas of low-visibility. Their crisis response communication was reactive and defensive, contributing to stakeholder mistrust and the placement of blame on the users. This report concludes that communication failures, rather than technical shortcomings alone, played a critical role in the crisis. Clearer, more proactive, and user-centered risk communication would have resulted in better public perception during this critical time for Character.AI.

Background

Recently, AI usage has been growing rapidly in popularity, and is becoming an integral part of our everyday lives, especially among younger users seeking connection (Morrone, 2025). Particularly, AI companion platforms have gained popularity among young adults who seek conversation, emotional support, or companionship (Morrone, 2025). Character.AI is a platform that allows users to interact with customizable personas that adopt friendly, empathetic, emotional support roles. These features have led to the company's rapid growth since their launch in 2022; however, they have also raised concerns about the psychological impacts of parasocial relationships between users and AI, especially among younger users (UNESCO, 2025).

Peer-reviewed research on social chatbots shows that users frequently form emotional, meaningful, relationship-like bonds with conversational agents (Skjuve et al., 2021). These interactions can foster anthropomorphism, the tendency to attribute human-like qualities to AI, which boosts engagement, but can also increase emotional dependence among users (Pentina et al.; Abduldattijo, 2025). Studies suggest that these attachments can blur boundaries between human and artificial relationships, potentially increasing emotional dependence and vulnerability among users who rely on chatbots for companionship or support (Pentina et al., 2023).

Character.AI began facing public scrutiny from 2024 to 2025, including multiple lawsuits from the Social Media Law Center on behalf of children who had either died by suicide or allegedly formed dependent relationships with the chatbots (Bhuiyan, 2025). News coverage and expert commentary argue that the company failed to effectively communicate the emotional risks of using their platform (Bhuiyan, 2025; Morrone, 2025). In response to the outrage, Character.AI announced several changes to their policies, including expanding disclaimers, updating safety messaging, and restricting access for minors (Character.AI, 2025 December). Since then, Character.AI has begun to restrict open-ended chat for users under 18 altogether,

and is planning to slowly decrease chat time limits over a few months (Character.AI, 2025 December).

This report examines the communication practices around Character.AI's crisis response, or lack thereof. Specifically, it analyzes how the company framed emotional and psychological risk across their platform, and how these framings interacted with media interpretation and public discourse. Understanding these communication choices and how they shape public perception is critical, as technical communication plays a critical role in guiding user expectations, assigning responsibility, and maintaining trust during moments of crisis (UNESCO, 2025).

Research Methods

This report employs qualitative rhetorical analysis to investigate how Character.AI framed emotional and psychological risk as they faced public scrutiny. This report examines how various stakeholders articulate responsibility, safety, and user risk through language, tone, and design decisions in official and public communications.

Primary sources for this analysis were pulled from Character.AI's official website, including the Safety Center page, Community Guidelines, and Terms of Service (Character.AI, 2025 December; Character.AI, n.d.; Character.AI n.d., 2025 August). These documents were selected for review because they represent the company's more direct and authoritative communication to users regarding safety expectations, acceptable use, and liability. Each document was read closely to identify how emotional risk was described, whether responsibility was taken by the platform or placed on the user, and how clearly potential harms were addressed. We pay special attention to disclaimers (e.g. "may", "not intended", "users are responsible"), language, and the placement and visibility of safety messaging within each document.

To contextualize Character.AI's internal messaging, we also draw on secondary sources, including news coverage from The Guardian and Axios and expert analysis from UNESCO on

parasocial AI relationships (Bhuiyan, 2025; Morrone, 2025; UNESCO, 2025). These sources help us understand how Character.AI's communication choices were received by journalists, policymakers, mental health experts, and the general public. Together, these sources help identify gaps between corporate messaging and external expectations of platform responsibility.

This report employs concepts from technical communication, such as risk communications, responsibility framing, and audience awareness. Patterns such as emphasis on disclaimer knowledge, how directly potential harms were addressed, and the prioritization of safety messaging visibility were observed throughout the documents. These qualitative methods show how communication practices, not just policy changes, affected public trust, confusion, and expectations during a crisis.

Findings

This incident report finds that communication choices played a central role in shaping how the public perceived both emotional and psychological risks of forming parasocial chatbot relationships while using Character.AI's platform. Character.AI's official communications minimized perceived risk, misplaced platform responsibility, and failed to proactively guide user expectations. These rhetorical choices contributed to the confusion, delayed understanding of potential harm, and weakened trust that happened as a response to the crisis from 2024 to 2025.

Finding 1: Emotional Risk Was Framed as User Misuse and an Unlikely Outcome

One key finding is that Character.AI framed emotional and psychological risk and something stemming from behavioral misuse, rather than a foreseeable outcome based on the platform's design (Character.AI, n.d.). In the Community Guidelines, the platform is emphasized to be an "immersive storytelling" experience, framing interactions as fictional and entertainment based rather than acknowledging the emotional nature of many user interactions (Character.AI, n.d.). However, prior studies demonstrate that emotional attachment to social chatbots is shaped by design features such as anthropomorphism, perceived authenticity, and

conversational continuity, making emotional dependency a predictable outcome of system design rather than an edge-case misuse (Pentina et al., 2023).

Furthermore, in the Terms of Service, the company similarly downplays the reliability and seriousness of chatbot interactions by noting that AI-generated chats “may produce Generated Content that is inaccurate or offensive” (Character.AI, 2025 August). These statements position emotional harm as unlikely rather than a predictable outcome of system design. This framing puts the blame on the user and positions emotional dependency as a byproduct of misuse rather than an inherent risk. By using speculative language (“may”, “could”, “not intended”) in the Terms of Service, Character.AI implies that harm occurs only under exceptional circumstances (Character.AI, 2025 August). As a result, users do not realize the serious risks of platform use and do not proceed with necessary caution. From a communication perspective, this choice weakens risk communication as it does not clearly articulate the scope and likelihood of harm. Rather than naming risks clearly, Character.AI treats risks as abstract possibilities, which may lead users to believe the platform is generally safe unless used improperly.

Finding 2: Responsibility of Emotional Harm Was Shifted Onto Users

While the previous finding shows that Character.AI minimized the likelihood of emotional harm, another significant finding is that the platform also shifted responsibility for managing that harm onto the users themselves. This emphasis in user accountability is seen primarily in the Terms of Service, which states that users must “must evaluate, and bear all risks associated with the use of any content or Generated Content” (Character.AI, 2025 August). By explicitly placing the burden of managing risk on the users, Character.AI frames potential harm as a matter of individual decision making. This reinforces the idea that users are responsible for interpreting chatbot interactions appropriately, even though the system's conversational features may encourage emotional engagement.

Throughout Character.AI's website, safety messaging is coupled with an emphasis on user accountability, and users are repeatedly reminded that characters are fictional and

individuals are responsible for their own emotional responses (Character.AI, 2025 August). This rhetorical strategy framed safety as a matter of individual judgment and does not account for how design features such as persistent memory, emotional validation, and conversational intimacy play into emotional attachment. Studies on long-term chatbot use indicate that these types of features promote emotional reliance, contradicting claims that responsibility for managing parasocial risk rests solely on the users (Skjuve et al., 2021; Pentina et al., 2023).

For vulnerable audiences like minors, this framing is particularly problematic. By assuming users possess the emotional literacy necessary to regulate parasocial engagement, Character.AI's communication overlooks audience diversity and risk profiles (UNESCO, 2025). This mismatch between audience needs and communication choices contributed to unrealistic expectations put onto users for self-regulation.

Finding 3: Safety Messaging was Low-Visibility and Reactive

Analysis also found that the organization and placement of safety messaging in Character.AI's platform reduced its effectiveness. Risk information was primarily found in secondary pages rather than as a core part of the user experience. This organization signals that safety is supplementary, not foundational. There is little evidence of in-context warnings embedded directly into conversations. From a design standpoint, this contradicts best practices of technical risk communication, which emphasizes visibility, repetition, and contextual relevance (UNESCO, 2025). As a result, many users encountered safety messaging only after media coverage brought attention to the issue. This reactive discovery undermines the reason for risk messaging in the first place, and amplifies the public perception that Character.AI deprioritized user well-being.

Furthermore, while Character.AI eventually updated its Safety Center to restrict access to minors as well as put parental controls in place, these changes were reactive to the crisis and they still failed to proactively protect their users. These changes were also communicated in a defensive and reactive tone, emphasizing clarification rather than accountability. The majority of

Character.AI's communication focused on reinforcing boundaries and legal protections (Character.AI, 2025 December), rather than acknowledging risk communication failures and the emotional impact on users.

New coverage from The Guardian and Axios reflected how this rhetorical approach shaped public perception. Many journalists and experts found these updates to be overdue, reinforcing skepticism of the company's prioritization of user safety (Bhuiyan, 2025; Morrone, 2025). This absence of empathic language negatively affected Character.AI's ability to build trust with the public during the crisis.

Overall, this report finds that there is a significant disconnect between Character.AI's internal messaging and stakeholder expectations. While Character.AI framed emotional risk as manageable through disclaimers and user awareness, outside experts and journalists found parasocial AI attachment to be a systematic concern built into the core of the platform. Expert analysis, such as UNESCO's discussion of these types of AI relationships, emphasizes that emotional bonds with AI are structurally encouraged rather than an accidental byproduct (UNESCO, 2025). This contrasts sharply with Character.AI's portrayal of user risk as unavoidable and as a symptom of misuse. This lack of alignment with stakeholder expectations and corporate communication exacerbated the crisis, intensified public criticism, and highlighted the consequences of inadequate risk framing.

Implications and Recommendations

First, this case shows the consequences of downplaying the potential for user harm. When communication frames risks as unlikely, users are less likely to set appropriate boundaries. In high-stakes systems like Character.AI that stimulate empathy and companionship, inadequate risk framing can exacerbate harm by encouraging emotional reliance, without setting appropriate boundaries.

Second, this case reveals that disclaimers and emphasis on user responsibility is not sufficient communication for these types of crises. While disclaimers reduce liability, they are not

an adequate form of public-facing risk communication. Over reliance on conditional language and policy documents undermines trust and does not align with how users best receive risk communication (UNESCO, 2025).

Finally, Character.AI's reactive response shows how delayed and defensive messaging can impact reputation and perception. When organizations wait until something goes wrong to put the correct systems in place, they lose credibility. This demonstrates that effective crisis communication must be proactive, visible, and empathetic.

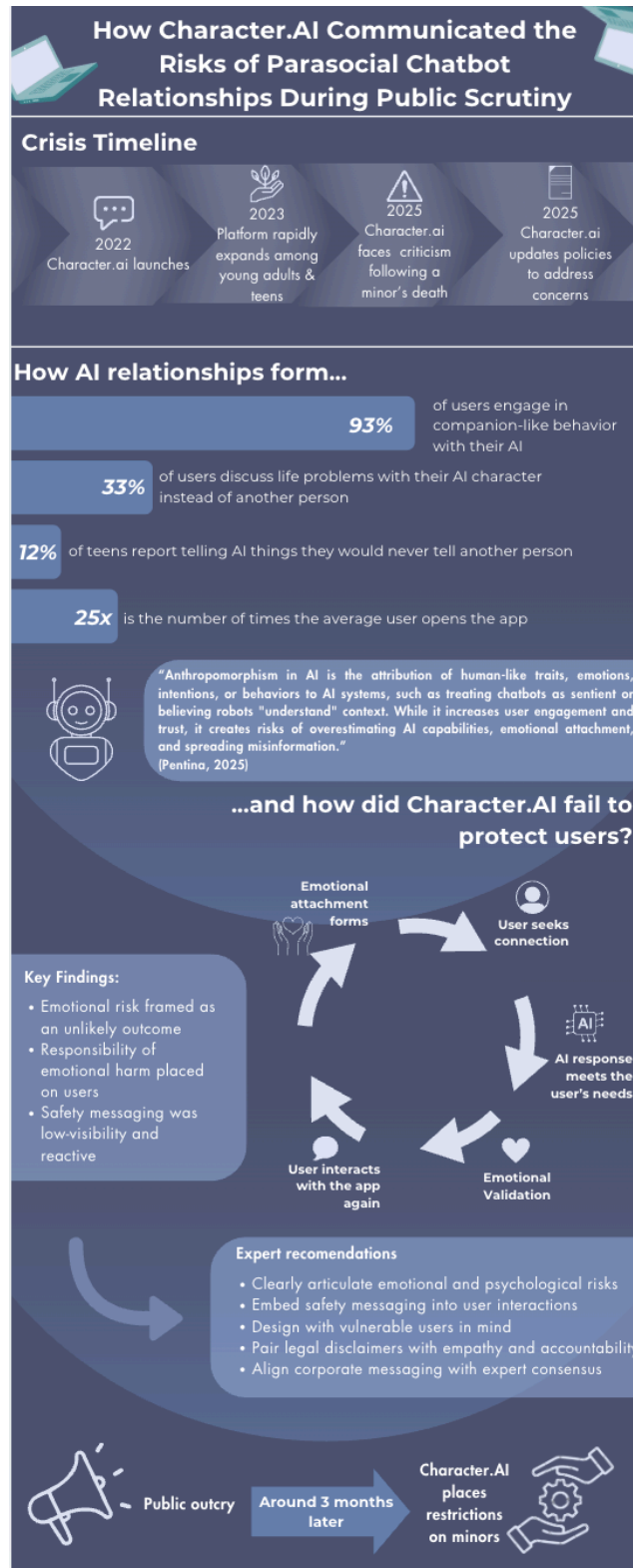
Based on these implications, this report offers the following recommendations for technical communicators and platform designers:

- Explicitly bring attention to emotional risks early and clearly; This helps users take the necessary steps to protect themselves and sets realistic expectations.
- Integrate safety messaging into the core user experience; Safety communication should be visually easy to find and easy for the users to understand.
- Use audience-centered risk communication; Messaging should account for diverse risk profiles, including vulnerable users like minors.
- Balance legal protection with empathy and accountability; Organizations should pair disclaimers with acknowledgement of harm and concern for affected users.
- Align internal messaging with stakeholder expectations; Technical communicators should engage with experts and journalists to ensure their messaging reflects understanding of risk and does not position harm as user-driven.

By adopting these recommendations, AI developers, product designers, and technical communication teams can better address the emotional risks associated with AI systems. These stakeholders play a key role in shaping how safety information is communicated to users and ensuring responsible innovation as tools like these continue to grow in usage and popularity. Implementing these practices would help organizations protect users, maintain public trust, and respond more effectively when crises arise.

Appendix

Appendix A: [Infographic](#)



Appendix B: References

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